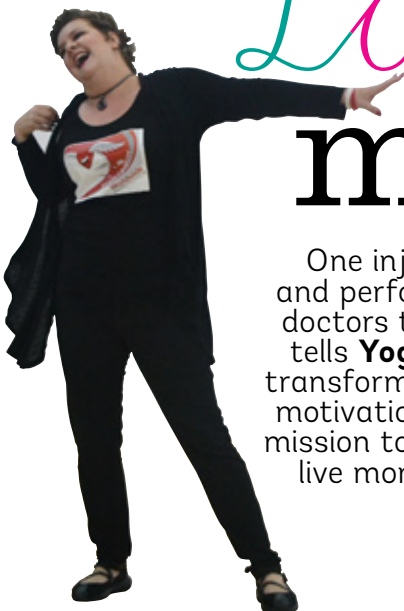




Laughter medicine



One injury changed everything for lead dancer and performer **Jo-Dee Wamsley**, who was told by doctors that she could never dance again. Jo-Dee tells **YogaLife** about the ensuing depression, the transformation she has undergone, her new life as a motivational speaker and why she has made it her mission to help people that face stress find ways to live more productive, healthier and happier lives.

IMAGES: SUPPLIED BY JO-DEE WAMSLEY & SHUTTERSTOCK

The first time I felt the incredible healing benefits of laughter, I was 21 years old. I was a young, successful lead dancer travelling the world and living a life that exceeded my expectations. I was being interviewed on television, had several features in international magazines and was thoroughly enjoying life. Then, all of a sudden, my knees gave way during a show in Macau. I tried, but I could hardly walk. I was in pain. I went for tests and was told I needed surgery. But when the doctor told me I would never dance again, I froze. *Surely it could not be true.* I didn't want to believe it. I had lost my mother a few months earlier and now this, everything I had ever worked for was falling to pieces.

I was stuck in Macau, which was not a particularly friendly place for a single young girl. Depressed and lost, I went to the cinema to watch a new film called *Amadeus*, a biographical film about Mozart, that had just been released. Mozart laughed at everything; he was a genius and people did not understand him, so he just laughed his way through life. I came out of the cinema feeling somewhat inspired and spirited. I tried to do the same: I laughed. Much to my surprise, it worked. I felt a sense of positivity, feeling that something would come out of my situation. I felt that there was another life I was meant to live, one that would fulfil me in an entirely different manner. Eventually, I forgot about this day until around five years ago. I had found myself in a mentally

abusive relationship. I was forced to leave my children, both for my own sanity and to put an end to the negative atmosphere

that was surrounding them. I had no idea what would happen, when I would see them again or how I would support myself, and I felt entirely tormented by this. I struggled financially to travel to see them and furthermore, was only allowed three to four days with them every few months, rules set out by my ex-husband. Living away from my children was of course devastating and during this dark and depressing phase of life, I found myself falling into another yet another bad relationship, partly from sheer loneliness. It was not a good time in my life.

A few years passed and one day, I found myself with my sister, reminiscing about that day of laughter so long ago inspired by a film on Mozart. "There must be something in it," she told me. "Google it." And that was when I stumbled upon Laughter Yoga. I saw an advertisement to become a Laughter Leader and, without giving it another thought, I booked it. I realised that I was short of money but somehow, once I made that decision to go on the course, the money appeared. Perhaps this was the law of attraction working, I thought, a law that through positivity and happiness, continued to work for me.

I trained with Dr Kataria, founder of Laughter Yoga, and am a qualified Laughter Teacher as well as Leader. I also had the pleasure of being mentored by a top speaker in the corporate world, Merv Neal, who helped me to share this wonderful tool to relieve stress and improve the lives of those around me.

Through Laughter Yoga, I found my confidence once again, the real me that had been hidden under layers of negativity and pain. And now I am ready to share this wonderful feeling with the world, such a simple natural activity that has a plethora of healing powers, unrealised until you try

DID YOU KNOW:
10 minutes of hearty laughter is equal to 30 minutes on a rowing machine?



Jo-Dee Wamsley taking a Laughter Yoga session

HERE ARE 5 WAYS FOR YOU TO TRY LAUGHING ON YOUR OWN:

GRADIENT LAUGHTER: Fake a smile, giggle, then laugh slowly and gradually increase tempo and volume.

HEARTY LAUGHTER: Spread your arms up, look up and laugh heartily.

DON'T KNOW WHY I AM LAUGHING: Laugh (fake is perfectly fine) and shrug your shoulders as you look at yourself in a mirror and try to convey the message with your eyes and body language, "I absolutely don't know why I am laughing."

LAUGHTER SHOWER: The best start to your day. As you start your morning routine start laughing as you move the shower from your feet all the way up. Laugh as you pass each part of your body; then as you brush your teeth; smile and laugh while you wash your face and brush your hair. Just laugh.

MENTAL FLOSS LAUGHTER: Move your hands sideways on either side of your head as if you were flossing your brain and laugh as you do so.

it, and addictive once you begin. I learned through laughter to break free from all things holding me down and have never looked back.

And through this, I have met so many wonderful Laughter Yogis around the world. I am truly blessed to be part of a community whose goals are towards living the best healthy life you can and striving for world peace.

So what exactly is laughter yoga?

Dr. Madan Kataria, an Indian physician popularly known as the 'Guru of Giggling' (*The Times*, UK), started the first laughter club with his wife Madhuri. It all began in a park in Mumbai on 13th March 1995 with just 5 people. Today, this revolutionary exercise routine has become a global phenomenon with more than 6,000 social laughter clubs in 60 countries. What makes it appealing to everyone is its universality – anyone can laugh without any reason. "Laughter is a choice," he said to a group of trainees. "A connector of people. No barriers. No language." Kataria says that laughter yoga "is based

upon the scientific fact that, even if you laugh for the sake of laughing, even if you are pretend laughing, your body cannot tell the difference."

And so this life-changing experience has now arrived in Dubai with Jo-Dee from Simply Laughter Worldwide. Laughter Yoga combines unconditional laughter with yogic breathing (pranayama), bringing more oxygen to the body and the brain which makes one feel more energetic and healthy.

Classes take place in businesses, fitness centres, yoga studios, centres for seniors, schools, colleges, universities, prisons and self-help cancer groups amongst others. Laughter is initiated as an exercise in a group, but with eye contact and childlike playfulness it soon turns into real and contagious laughter.

SCIENTIFICALLY PROVEN

Clinical research on Laughter Yoga methods conducted at the University of Graz in Austria, Bangalore and in the United States, has shown that laughter lowers the level of stress hormones (epinephrine and cortisol) in the blood. It fosters a positive attitude so you are less likely to succumb to stress, depression and helplessness if one is able to laugh away the troubles.

HEALTH BENEFITS

Laughter yoga is a powerful cardio workout. ten minutes of hearty laughter is equal to 30 minutes on a rowing machine. It decreases the negative effects of stress on your body, this being the root cause to most illnesses. Laughter yoga is a single exercise that deals with physical, mental and emotional stress simultaneously. It strengthens the immune system, lowers the blood pressure, controls blood sugar and keeps your heart healthy. It is a powerful antidote against depression.

Students are full of positive energy that makes it easy to cope with stress and impossible to feel depressed. In fact, the impact of laughter is so profound that many practitioners claim they no longer need antidepressants. The sustained positive emotions keep them coming back for more. Participants report significant health improvements. Many feel a reduced frequency of respiratory infections like common cold and flu, while others report depression lifting and chronic medical problems improving or even disappearing.

The ultimate objective is to bring good health, joy and peace. Laughter Yoga clubs are fast developing into a worldwide community of people who believe in unconditional love and laughter. ✨

Simply Laughter has just launched sessions in Dubai.

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